posted nearby. When we were in Delhi, they were in Meerut and weekend visits were the norm. Then, we were in Delhi together, so the visits became even more frequent. Seeing Veena and I play like this, my grandmother, Ai, would often say in exasperation, '*Yencha lagna lavayla pahijay*' (we should get them married). We were inseparable and more importantly, not mischief-mongers.

In mid-1975, my father was posted to the Equipment Depot at Devlali, Maharashtra. It was his second posting to Devlali. He had been posted there earlier in the 1960s, and that's where I was born, in the Military Hospital, Devlali Cantonment. Apart from the Air Force Station, Devlali is also home to the School of Artillery and the Artillery Regimental Centre. Since my brother was in his final year, we had to stay back in Delhi till the end of the academic year, i.e., till March–April 1976. I had gone into the 9th Standard and, along with some friends, selected a strange combination of subjects: English, physics, chemistry, maths, engineering drawing and bookkeeping and accountancy. I don't recollect whose bright idea it was, and the school tried its best to dissuade us but to no avail. They had to open a new section just for us. The upshot was that when it was time to leave Delhi, there was no school in Devlali offering the latter two subjects in this combo. My parents cast the net wider and chanced upon a school in Pune willing to consider this, provided I passed their admission test, which was not a standard written exam but an IQ test. I don't know what was the cut-off criteria (best not to ask/know), but apparently, I qualified, and that's how I came to join Jnana Prabodhini Prashala, Sadashiv Peth, Pune.

Dr Vinayak Vishvanath Pendse, fondly called Appa Saheb, was a visionary educationist. As a true patriot, he had taken an active part in the freedom struggle. Immediately after

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